

has excellent bass reproduction and extremely good treble. The clarity is unmatched in this class, and if you have the dough, this is the way to go! The dark horse here was the Cyber Acoustic CA4100.

Compared to the 641, it was quite simply outclassed, but you must also remember that for the price of the 641, you can get a



Altec Lansing 641 (4.1)

really good 5.1! So to be fair to the Cyber Acoustic, it did a very commendable job for the right price, to come in second.

The Creative, on the other hand, paled in comparison to the Altec Lansing, and was also quite clearly beaten by the Cyber Acoustic in terms of price versus performance. But it is still a fairly good buy at Rs 3,290—especially when compared to the 641's price tag of Rs 20,000!

The Real Thing: 5.1

If you are positively appalled at the notion of pseudo-surround at 4.1, and will settle for nothing but the real thing, then 5.1 systems are for you! We sounded out a whopping 20 systems in this category.

Out Of The Box

This was the category where we expected to see speakers crammed with features and to be of top-notch quality, both in terms of build quality as well as sound reproduction, and most manufacturers did come through.

Almost all the speakers lacked multiple input types, and mostly came with the regular 5.1 input along with auxiliary and stereo inputs. Very few had digital inputs, whether optical or coaxial, except for the Altec Lansing BS 3151R, which had a digital DIN. None of the speakers had S/PDIF input.

Almost all these speakers came with a remote control, either wired or wireless; the exceptions were the Altec Lansing 251, Jazz and Mercury. None of the speakers came with an inbuilt FM tuner, either; again, this could have been a useful addition.

The process of setting up the speakers was more or less identical with all the brands, except for the Logitech and Philips speakers, which used colour-coded wires making installation even easier.

The other type of speakers, in terms of setup, came with raw wires and clamps—no plugs, nothing. You need to open the clamp, and put in the wires with care so that the clamp and connector is actually touching the metal inside and not the wire insulation.

But actually, wires of this type are better than the ones provided by Philips or Logitech, since the sound quality of speakers is very much dependent on the wires (they carry the sound, remember?). It can sometimes make sense to go for a higher quality wire than the one provided, and thus enhance the listening experience.

An additional benefit is that if you need to extend the wire or replace a broken one, it is far easier to do it with this kind of wire.

The weirdest systems to set up were the Mercury systems. On connecting and calibrating the systems, we realised that the colour coding at the back of the subwoofer was mixed up, so we spent some agonising minutes trying to figure out which wire went where—a wholly unnecessary exercise, since colour coding is supposed to make the task easier!

We got very varied designs in terms of speakers. The snazziest looking were the Artis S7100. These tall, slim speakers with glass bases are what you put in your house if you are looking for elegance and class.

The Creatives looked rather plain in comparison to most of the others, and continued to carry their usual design. The Logitech Z5300 looked to be on track with Logitech's design

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